Inherit the Wind

By Robert E. Lee and Jerome Lawrence

DRUMMOND: Your Honor, the court has ruled out any evidence as to scientific knowledge or the Darwinian theory. *(There's the glint of an idea in his eye)* Would the court admit expert testimony regarding a book known as the Holy Bible? *(Listen for "unspoken" answer)* Thank you. *(With relish)* I call to the stand one of the world's foremost experts on the Bible and its teachings- Matthew Harrison Brady!

INTRODUCTION

Inherit the Wind is based on the furor that erupted in 1925 when Tennessee schoolteacher John Scopes (referenced here as Professor Cates) was prosecuted for introducing the subject of evolution into his public school classroom. The resulting "Monkey Trial" pitted the orator and Biblical scholar William Jennings Bryant (Matthew Harrison Brady in this play- gesture to Actor 2) against the brilliant defense attorney Clarence Darrow (gesture to self - Mr. Drummond) in a courtroom confrontation that attracted worldwide attention. Inherit the Wind by Robert E. Lee and Jerome Lawrence

(BRADY sits, confident and assured. His air is that of a benign and learned mathematician about to be quizzed by a schoolboy on matters of short division.)

DRUMMOND: Am I correct, sir, in calling on you as an authority on the Bible?

BRADY: I believe it is not boastful to say that I have studied the Bible as much as any layman. And I have tried to live according to its precepts.

DRUMMOND: Bully for you. Now, I suppose you can quote me chapter and verse right straight through the King James Version, can't you?

BRADY: There are many portions of the Holy Bible that I have committed to memory. *(DRUMMOND crosses to counsel table and picks up a copy of Darwin.)*

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DRUMMOND: I don't suppose you've memorized many passages from the *Origin of Species*?

BRADY: I am not in the least interested in the pagan hypotheses of that book.

DRUMMOND: Never read it?

BRADY: And I never will.

DRUMMOND: Then how in perdition do you have the gall to whoop up this holy war against something you don't know anything about? How can you be so sure that the body of scientific knowledge systematized in the writings of Charles Darwin is, in any way, irreconcilable with the spirit of the Book of Genesis?

BRADY: Would you state that question again, please?

DRUMMOND: *(Not angrily)* All right. I get the scent in the wind. *(He tosses the volume of Darwin on the counsel table)* We'll play in *your* ball park, Colonel. *(He searches for a copy of the Bibl,. Without opening it, DRUMMOND scrutinizes the binding from several angles)* Now let's get this straight. Let's get it clear. This is the book that you're an expert on? *(BRADY is annoyed at DRUMMOND'S elementary attitude and condescension.)*

BRADY: That is correct.

DRUMMOND: Now tell me. Do you feel that every word that's written in this book should be taken literally?

BRADY: Everything in the Bible should be accepted, exactly as it is given there.

DRUMMOND: I recollect a story about Joshua, making the sun stand still. Now as an expert, you tell me that as true as the Jonah business. Right? *(BRADY nods, blandly)* That's a pretty neat trick. You suppose Houdini could do it?

BRADY: I do not question or scoff at the miracles of the Lord- as do ye of little faith.

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DRUMMOND: If they say that the sun stood still, they must've had a notion that the sun moves around the earth. Think that's the way of things? Or don't you believe the earth moves around the sun?

BRADY: I have faith in the Bible! *(Doggedly)* The sun stopped.

DRUMMOND: Good. *(Level and direct.)* Now if what you say actually happened- if Joshua halted the sun in the sky- that means the earth stopped spinning on its axis; continents toppled over each other, mountains flew out into space. And the earth, arrested in its orbit, shriveled to a cinder and crashed into the sun. *(Turning)* How come they missed *this* tidbit of news?

BRADY: They missed it because it didn't happen.

DRUMMOND: It must've happened! According to natural law. Or don't you believe in natural law, Colonel? Would you like to ban Copernicus from the classroom, along with Charles Darwin? Pass a law to wipe out all the scientific development since Joshua? Revelations- period!

BRADY: *(Calmly, as if instructing a child)* Natural law was born in the mind of the Heavenly Father. He can change it, cancel it, use it as He pleases. It constantly amazes me that you apostles of science, for all your supposed wisdom, fail to grasp this simple fact. *(DRUMMOND flips a few pages in the Bible.)* The Bible satisfies me, it is enough.

DRUMMOND: It frightens me to imagine the state of learning in this world if everyone had your driving curiosity. *(DRUMMOND is still probing for a weakness in Goliath's armor. He thumbs a few pages in the Bible.)* The book goes into a lot of "begats." *(He reads)* "And Aphraxad begat Salah; and Salah begat Eber" and so on and so on. These pretty important folks?

BRADY: They are the generations of the holy men and women of the Bible.

DRUMMOND: Did people "begat" in those days about the same way they get themselves "begat" today?

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BRADY: The process is about the same. I don't think your scientists have improved it any.

DRUMMOND: In other words, these folks were conceived and brought forth through the normal biological function known as sex. What do you think of sex, Colonel Brady? I'm not asking what you think of sex as a father, or as a husband. You're up here as an expert on the Bible. What's the Biblical evaluation of sex?

BRADY: It is considered "Original Sin."

DRUMMOND: *(With mock amazement)* And all these holy people got themselves "begat" through "Original Sin"? *(BRADY does not answer. He scowls, and shifts his weight in his chair.)* All this sinning make 'em any less holy?

BRADY: *(With dignity)* Your Honor, I am willing to sit here and endure Mr. Drummond's sneering and his disrespect. For he is pleading the case of the prosecution by his contempt for all that is holy.

DRUMMOND: I object, I object, I object.

BRADY: On what grounds? Is it possible that something *is* holy to the celebrated agnostic?

DRUMMOND: *Yes! (His voice drops, intensely)* The individual human mind. In a child's power to master the multiplication table there is more sanctity than in all your shouted "Amens!", "Holy, Holies!" and "Hosannahs!" An idea is a greater monument than a cathedral. And the advance of man's knowledge is more of a miracle than any sticks turned to snakes, or the parting of waters! But are we now to halt the march of progress because Mr. Brady frightens us with a fable? *(Thoughtfully, seeming to look beyond the courtroom)* Darwin moved us forward to a hilltop, where we can look back and see the way from which we came. But for this view, this insight, this knowledge, we must abandon our faith in the pleasant poetry of Genesis.

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BRADY: We must *not* abandon faith! Faith is the important thing!

DRUMMOND: Then why did God plague us with the power to think? Mr. Brady, why do you deny the *one* faculty which lifts man above all other creatures of the earth: the power of his brain to reason. What other merits have we? The elephant is larger, the horse is stronger and swifter, the butterfly is more beautiful, the mosquito more prolific, even the simple sponge is more durable! *(Wheeling on BRADY)* Or does a *sponge* think?

BRADY: If the Lord wishes a sponge to think, it thinks.

DRUMMOND: Does a man have the same privileges that a sponge does?

BRADY: Of course.

DRUMMOND: *(Roaring for the first time: stretching his arm towards CATES – his client)* This man wishes to be accorded the same privilege as a sponge! *He wishes to think!*

BRADY: But your client is wrong! He is deluded! He has lost his way!

DRUMMOND: It's sad that we aren't all gifted with your positive knowledge of Right and Wrong, Mr. Brady.

(DRUMMOND strides to one of the uncalled witnesses seated behind him and takes from him a rock, about the size of a tennis ball. DRUMMOND weighs the rock in his hand as he saunters back toward BRADY)

DRUMMOND: How old do you think this rock is?

BRADY: *(Intoning)* I am more interested in the Rock of Ages, than I am in the Age of Rocks.

DRUMMOND: Dr. Page of Oberlin College tells me that this rock is at least ten million years old. *(DRUMMOND opens up the rock, which splits into two halves. He shows it to BRADY)* Look, Mr. Brady. These are the fossil remains of a pre-historic marine creature, which was found in this very county- and which

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lived here millions of years ago, when these very mountain ranges were submerged in water.

BRADY: I know. The Bible gives a fine account of the flood. But your professor is a little mixed up on his dates. That rock is not more than six thousand years old.

DRUMMOND: How do you know?

BRADY: A fine Biblical scholar, Bishop Usher, has determined for us the exact date and hour of the Creation. It occurred in the year 4004 B.C.

DRUMMOND: That's Bishop Usher's opinion.

BRADY: It is not an opinion. It is a literal fact, which the good Bishop arrived at through careful computation of the ages of the prophets as set down in the Old Testament. In fact, he determined that the Lord began the Creation on the 23rd of October in the Year 4004 B.C. at- uh, at 9 A.M.!

DRUMMOND: That Eastern Standard Time? Or Rocky Mountain Time? It wasn't daylight-saving time, was it? Because the Lord didn't make the sun until the fourth day!

BRADY: *(Fidgeting)* That is correct.

DRUMMOND: *(Sharply)* The first day. Was it a twenty-four-hour day?

BRADY: The Bible says it was a day.

DRUMMOND: There wasn't any sun. How do you know how long it was? A normal day, a literal day, a twenty-four-hour day? *(Pause. BRADY is unsure.)*

BRADY: I do not know.

DRUMMOND: Isn't it possible that first day was twenty-*five* hours long? There was no way to measure it, no way to tell! *Could* it have been twenty-five hours?

BRADY: *(Hesitates- then)* It is . . . *possible* . . .

(DRUMMOND'S got him. And he knows it! This is the turning point. From here on, the tempo mounts. DRUMMOND is now fully in the driver's seat. He pounds his questions faster and faster.)

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DRUMMOND: Oh. You interpret that the first day recorded in the Book of Genesis could be of indeterminate length. It could have been thirty hours! Or a month! Or a year! Or a hundred years! *(He brandishes the rock underneath BRADY'S nose)* Or *ten million years!*

(Both BRADY and DRUMMOND crane forward, hurling their answers not at the court, but at each other.)

BRADY: [You] want to destroy everybody's belief in the Bible, and in God!

DRUMMOND: You know that's not true. I'm trying to stop you bigots and ignoramuses from controlling the education of the United States! And you know it!

BRADY: How dare you attack the Bible?

DRUMMOND: The Bible is a book. A good book. But it's not the *only* book.

BRADY: It is the revealed word of the Almighty. God spake to the men who wrote the Bible.

DRUMMOND: And how do you know that God didn't "spake" to Charles Darwin?

BRADY: I know because God tells me to oppose the evil teachings of that man.

DRUMMOND: Oh. God speaks to you.

BRADY: Yes.

DRUMMOND: He tells you exactly what's right and what's wrong? And you act accordingly?

BRADY: Yes.

DRUMMOND: So you, Matthew Harrison Brady, through oratory, legislation, or whatever, pass along God's orders to the rest of the world! Gentlemen, meet the "Prophet from Nebraska!"

BRADY: *(Almost inarticulate)* Please-!

DRUMMOND: *(With increasing tempo, closing in)* Is that the way of things? God tells Brady what is good! To be against Brady is to be against God!

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BRADY: *(Confused)* No, no! Each man is a free agent-

DRUMMOND: Then what is Bertram Cates doing in the Hillsboro jail? Suppose Mr. Cates had enough influence and lung power to railroad through the State Legislature a law that only *Darwin* should be taught in the schools!

BRADY: Ridiculous, ridiculous! There is only one great Truth in the world-

DRUMMOND: The Gospel according to Brady! God speaks to Brady, and Brady tells the world! Brady, Brady, Brady, Almighty! *(DRUMMOND bows grandly).*

BRADY: The Lord is my strength-

DRUMMOND: What if a lesser human being- a Cates, or a Darwin- has the audacity to think that God might whisper to *him*? That an un-Brady thought might still be holy? Must men go to prison because they are at odds with the self-appointed prophet?

(BRADY is now trembling so that it is impossible for him to speak. He rises, towering above his tormentor- rather like a clumsy, lumbering bear that is baited by an agile dog)

DRUMMOND: Extend the Testaments! Let us have a Book of Brady! We shall hex the Pentateuch, and slip you in neatly between Numbers and Deuteronomy!

BRADY: *(Reaching for a sympathetic ear, trying to find the loyal audience which has slipped away from him)* My friends- Your Honor- My Followers- Ladies and Gentlemen

DRUMMOND: The witness is excused.

BRADY: *(Unheeding)* All of you know what I stand for! What I believe! I believe, I believe in the truth of the Book of Genesis! *(Beginning to chant)* Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, Joshua, Judges, Ruth, First Samuel, Second Samuel, First Kings, Second Kings-

DRUMMOND: Your Honor, this completes the testimony. The witness is excused!

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